

Shipping and Delivery Operations Policy

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Owner: Logistics Operations **Review Frequency:** Quarterly

1. Purpose

This policy defines the operational procedures for monitoring shipments, identifying delayed deliveries, communicating delays to customers, and escalating shipment issues to logistics personnel.

The objective is to ensure that delayed orders are identified consistently and that customers receive accurate information without employees or automated systems making unsupported promises.

2. Standard Delivery Expectations

Orders are assigned an expected delivery date when the shipment is created.

The expected delivery date is determined using:

* Customer delivery location * Shipping method * Carrier service level * Order processing time * Warehouse availability * Applicable weekends and public holidays

The expected delivery date should be treated as the primary reference point for determining whether an order is delayed.

An order is considered delayed when the current date is later than the expected delivery date and the order has not been confirmed as delivered.

3. Delay Classification

Shipment delays are classified according to the number of calendar days past the expected delivery date.

0-1 Days Late

Orders that are between zero and one day late are considered **minor delays**.

Recommended action:

* Continue shipment monitoring. * No manual carrier contact is normally required. * Customer contact is optional unless the customer has already contacted support.

The system should not automatically issue compensation for a delay of one day or less.

2-4 Days Late

Orders delayed between two and four days are considered ****moderate delays****.

Recommended action:

* Review the latest shipment status. * Verify whether tracking information has been updated within the previous 48 hours. * Notify the customer when meaningful tracking information is available. * Contact the carrier if the shipment has not received a tracking update for more than 48 hours.

5-7 Days Late

Orders delayed between five and seven days are considered ****high-priority delays****.

Required actions:

1. Review order information. 2. Review shipment information. 3. Verify the tracking number. 4. Determine the most recent carrier scan. 5. Check whether the shipment appears stalled. 6. Contact the carrier when no meaningful tracking movement has occurred. 7. Notify the customer about the delay. 8. Create an internal support record when carrier intervention is required.

Orders in this category should receive priority over ordinary delivery-status requests.

More Than 7 Days Late

Orders delayed by more than seven days require ****escalated investigation****.

Required actions:

* Verify order information. * Verify customer information. * Review the complete available shipment history. * Contact the carrier. * Determine whether the shipment may be lost, misrouted, or returned. * Notify the customer. * Create or update a support ticket. * Escalate to a human logistics specialist.

The automated system must not independently declare a shipment lost.

4. Missing Tracking Information

A shipment may occasionally exist without a valid tracking number or without a usable tracking status.

If an order is delayed and both tracking number and shipment status are unavailable:

1. Do not invent or infer a tracking number. 2. Do not tell the customer that the shipment is moving. 3. Verify whether a shipment record exists. 4. Check the order's fulfillment status. 5. Escalate to logistics if the shipment cannot be verified. 6. Inform the customer that the shipment requires additional investigation.

Missing tracking information for an order delayed more than five days should normally result in human review.

5. Tracking Inactivity

A shipment is considered inactive when no meaningful carrier tracking event has occurred for more than 48 hours.

Examples of meaningful tracking events include:

* Package accepted by carrier * Package departed facility * Package arrived at facility * Package transferred to another carrier facility * Package out for delivery * Delivery attempt

Administrative events that do not indicate physical movement should not necessarily be considered meaningful movement.

When tracking has been inactive for more than 48 hours:

* Review the shipment. * Check whether the carrier has reported an exception. * Contact the carrier when appropriate. * Avoid promising a new delivery date unless the carrier has provided one.

6. Carrier Exceptions

Carrier exceptions may include:

* Incorrect address * Weather disruption * Transportation disruption * Customs processing * Damaged package * Recipient unavailable * Delivery restriction * Sorting error * Returned shipment

The system should report the carrier-provided exception rather than attempting to determine the cause independently.

If an exception prevents delivery and requires customer information, customer contact should be recommended.

If the exception indicates potential loss or damage, the issue should be escalated.

7. Estimated Delivery Dates

Customer support and automated agents must not guarantee delivery on a specific date unless the carrier explicitly confirms the date.

Acceptable:

> "The latest carrier information indicates that the package is currently expected to arrive tomorrow."

Not acceptable:

> "Your package will definitely arrive tomorrow."

If no reliable estimated delivery date exists, the customer should be informed that the shipment is still under investigation.

8. Customer Communication

Customer messages regarding delayed orders should include:

* Confirmation that the order is delayed. * The latest verified shipment information. * The next operational step when known. * An appropriate expectation for follow-up.

Customer communications must not include:

* Invented tracking information. * Unsupported delivery dates. * Claims that a carrier has been contacted when no contact occurred. * Guarantees of delivery. * Compensation promises unless authorized by the refund or compensation policy.

9. Escalation Rules

Human intervention is required when:

* Shipment information is missing for an order delayed more than five days. * An order is delayed more than seven days. * The shipment appears potentially lost. * The shipment appears damaged. * The shipment has contradictory tracking information. * The carrier reports an unresolved exception. * Customer information is required to resolve a delivery exception. * The automated system cannot determine an appropriate operational action.

10. Automation Restrictions

The automated operations agent may:

* Retrieve order information. * Retrieve shipment information. * Search company policies. * Classify delay severity. * Recommend operational actions. * Draft customer communications. * Recommend carrier contact. * Recommend escalation.

The automated operations agent may not:

* Change shipment status. * Change delivery dates. * Mark a shipment as delivered. * Declare a package lost. * Promise compensation. * Modify customer information. * Contact a carrier without an authorized workflow. * Send a customer communication without the required approval workflow.

11. Conflict Resolution

When multiple sources contain shipment information, the system should prioritize:

1. Current carrier tracking information.
2. Internal shipment records.
3. Order records.
4. Historical support records.

If sources conflict and the conflict cannot be resolved automatically, human review is required.

12. Operational Principle

The system must prefer ****verified information and escalation over speculation****.

When sufficient information is unavailable to make a reliable decision, the correct action is to identify the missing information and request human investigation.